religious sponsorship they formed SS battalions, numbering some 250,000, integrated into the German army or serving in the Nazi extermination camps.

Peace in 1945 silenced these antisemitic Nazi Euro-Arab networks but it did not suppress them. Diverse channels discretely helped important Nazi functionaries to reach Arab countries, mainly Egypt and Syria, while France hosted the Mufti, saving him from the Nuremberg tribunal. When it became too embarrassing, Paris organized the Mufti's safe passage in May 1946 from Paris to Cairo. Here, he would once again collaborate with Nazis who had found their way to the Middle East.

Converted to Islam, Nazi exiles in Arab military dictatorships contributed to strengthening anti-Jewish repression and Nazi-style antisemitic propaganda. Using their connections with their former European colleagues, recycled in the administrations of postwar Europe, they helped restore in the following decades a Euro-Arab solidarity directed against the state of Israel.

The fate of the Jews was a minor issue in the war conducted by the Allies in the 1940s against Nazi Germany and European Fascism. Hence after the war, the virulent antisemitism and anti-Zionism (shaped already in the 1920s and by the Nazi-Arab alliance which included the Muslim Brotherhood), re-emerged albeit in a more clandestine way before 1967.

During this period the Vatican's Second Ecumenical Council (1962–1965) aroused religious tensions. Arab clerics were utilized by Arab states wishing to maintain the traditional opprobrium of the Jewish people in Christian teaching. These conflicts were particularly embittered in a postwar France that still remained the Church's eldest daughter and where the active collaboration of the wartime Pétain government with the Nazis in the deportation of Jews still held fresh memories.

In the 1960s, the heirs of Pétainist France rallied violent Arab Christian and Muslim opposition to the Jewish-Christian reconciliation promoted by the Vatican Council. This historical context aroused an unconditional (even visceral for some) sense of empathy toward the Arabs of Palestine. Arab Christians and Europeans went as far as identifying Palestine as the embodiment of a Muslim-Christian Jesus crucified by Israel on the Cross. This was a figure of Christ-like adoration in which Islam and Christianity could mystically unite in oneness against an imagined Jewish "conspiracy."[2]

Meanwhile Eastern Arab Churches made the criminalization of Zionism in the West a basic and essential condition for Muslim-Christian rapprochement. Serving their Muslim masters, they became the major instruments for spreading anti-Zionism in Europe. Elimination of the Jewish state became a priority more important than defending their own Christian communities. The most eminent personalities of this current, which became a

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